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POLISH EARLY MUSIC

# Singing Polish and Polish Latin

*A pronunciation guide to the editions*



Modern Polish · Polish of the sixteenth century · Old Polish · Latin as sung in Poland

GUIDE

by Mikołaj Derduń

First edition · 2026

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Source files, corrections and later editions: <https://github.com/mderdun/pol-ren/editions/pronunciation>.

Set in Junicode by Peter S. Baker, in a pressed variant made for the series.

## HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

**T**HE EDITIONS print each text in its own spelling and leave the sounds to this guide. An edition's notes mention only what is peculiar to its text. Sounds are described by comparison with English, Polish or Italian words. Syllables are divided with hyphens where the division matters for underlay, and the stressed syllable is in capitals: po-PROŚ-my.

Each section gives the series default first: what the editions assume and what their underlay is built on. Historical options follow, with the evidence for each. Take an option only if the whole choir can keep it, and say so in the programme. A mixed pronunciation is worse than either.

## MODERN POLISH

Polish spelling is regular. A letter or a pair of letters has one sound, with a few rules of context given below. Every vowel is a full vowel, never reduced to the neutral vowel of English *about*. Stress falls on the next-to-last syllable.

| SPELLING                      | SOUND                                                                               | EXAMPLE                |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| VOWELS                        |                                                                                     |                        |
| <i>a</i>                      | as in <i>father</i> , short                                                         | <i>matka</i>           |
| <i>e</i>                      | as in <i>bed</i>                                                                    | <i>dzień</i>           |
| <i>i</i>                      | as in <i>machine</i> , short                                                        | <i>miły</i>            |
| <i>o</i>                      | as in British <i>hot</i>                                                            | <i>noc</i>             |
| <i>ó, u</i>                   | as in <i>food</i> , but short; the two letters sound the same                       | <i>Bóg, używać</i>     |
| <i>y</i>                      | near the <i>i</i> of <i>bit</i> , with the tongue drawn back                        | <i>był, chytróść</i>   |
| <i>ą</i>                      | nasal o, as in French <i>bon</i> (see below)                                        | <i>są</i>              |
| <i>ę</i>                      | nasal e, as in French <i>vin</i> (see below)                                        | <i>męka</i>            |
| CONSONANTS                    |                                                                                     |                        |
| <i>c</i>                      | <i>ts</i> as in <i>cats</i>                                                         | <i>noc</i>             |
| <i>ch, h</i>                  | as in Scottish <i>loch</i>                                                          | <i>chytróść</i>        |
| <i>cz</i>                     | <i>ch</i> as in <i>church</i> , tongue drawn back                                   | <i>czart</i>           |
| <i>ć; ci before a vowel</i>   | a soft <i>ch</i> , tongue against the hard palate                                   | <i>ciemność</i>        |
| <i>dz</i>                     | <i>ds</i> as in <i>adds</i>                                                         | <i>dzwon</i>           |
| <i>dź; dzi before a vowel</i> | a soft <i>j</i> , as <i>ć</i> but voiced                                            | <i>chodzi</i>          |
| <i>dż</i>                     | <i>j</i> as in <i>jam</i> , tongue drawn back                                       | <i>dżdżysty</i>        |
| <i>g</i>                      | always hard, as in <i>go</i>                                                        | <i>Boga</i>            |
| <i>j</i>                      | <i>y</i> as in <i>yes</i>                                                           | <i>jesteś</i>          |
| <i>ł</i>                      | <i>w</i> as in <i>wet</i>                                                           | <i>był</i>             |
| <i>ń; ni before a vowel</i>   | <i>ny</i> as in <i>canyon</i>                                                       | <i>Panie</i>           |
| <i>r</i>                      | rolled, as in Italian                                                               | <i>Kryste</i>          |
| <i>rz, ż</i>                  | <i>s</i> as in <i>measure</i> , tongue drawn back; the two spellings sound the same | <i>strażem, rzeczy</i> |
| <i>s</i>                      | as in <i>sun</i>                                                                    | <i>syn</i>             |
| <i>ś; si before a vowel</i>   | a soft <i>sh</i> , tongue against the hard palate                                   | <i>się</i>             |
| <i>sz</i>                     | <i>sh</i> as in <i>shop</i> , tongue drawn back                                     | <i>nasze</i>           |
| <i>w</i>                      | <i>v</i>                                                                            | <i>wieczny</i>         |

| SPELLING                    | SOUND                                     | EXAMPLE      |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------|
| <i>z</i>                    | as in <i>zoo</i>                          | <i>złych</i> |
| <i>ż; zi before a vowel</i> | a soft <i>zh</i> , as <i>ś</i> but voiced | <i>zima</i>  |

*The silent i.* Between a consonant and a vowel, *i* only softens the consonant. It is not a vowel and never takes a note: *się* is one syllable, *Panie* two (PA-nie), *miłosierny* four (mi-ło-SIER-ny). Elsewhere *i* is a vowel. Latin and borrowed words are different (see the Latin section).

*Nasal vowels.* *Ą* and *ę* are true nasal vowels before *s, z, sz, ż, ś, ź, f, w, ch* and at the end of a word: the vowel, then a nasal glide towards *w*. Before *p, b, t, d, k, g* and the like they become the vowel plus *m, n* or *ng*: *męka* sounds as *menka*, *święty* as *świenty*, *zab* as *zomp*. Before *l* and *ł* they lose their nasality. At the end of a word *ę* is usually a plain *e* in speech. On a long note, hold the plain vowel and let the nasal come only at the end of the note, as it does in speech.

*Voicing.* A voiced consonant at the end of a word is voiceless: *Bóg* sounds *buk*. In a cluster the consonants agree with the last one: *wszystko* sounds *fszytko*, *swey* *sfej*, *przez* *pszes*. A one-letter preposition joins the next word: *w ciemności* is sung as one word, beginning with *f*.

*Stress.* On the next-to-last syllable: *po-PROŚ-my, u-ży-WA-ją*. Short unstressed words (*się, mi, cię, go, nas*) lean on the word before.

#### POLISH OF THE SIXTEENTH CENTURY

*Default.* Modern pronunciation of the old forms as printed. The editions keep forms such as *zmierzka, naszym, swoje, wszystkie, jenż* because they change rhyme, syllable count or sense. Their sounds changed gradually and unevenly over two centuries, and singing them in modern pronunciation is what Polish choirs do. Sing *naszem* with *-em*, *swoje* with a nasal *e*, exactly as written.

The following historical options are attested for the Polish of about 1550. They are listed from the best attested and easiest to the least certain.

*Ł as a dark l.* In the sixteenth century *ł* was a true *l*, the dark *l* of English *full*, and not yet the *w* of modern Polish. The change began around 1600 and became standard only in the twentieth century; stage speech kept the dark *l* until then. This is the safest historical option.

*Rz as a trilled fricative.* Written *rz* began as a soft *r*. By the fourteenth century it had become an *r* trilled with friction, the sound of Czech *ř* in *Dvořák*. It merged with *ż* gradually between the sixteenth and eighteenth centuries, earlier in some places than in others. For Kraków around 1550 it is defensible.

*Stress over the stress group.* Stress already fell on the next-to-last syllable, but it was counted over the whole group, including a short word leaning on the one before. *Stało się* was stressed *sta-ŁO się*, where modern Polish has *STA-ło się*. This matters at a cadence where *się, mi* or *cię* follows a two-syllable word.

*Nasal vowels.* In the sixteenth century *ą* was still closer to a nasal *a* than a nasal *o*; it reached its modern sound in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. *Ę* was more open than now, towards the *a* of English *cat*.

*Narrowed vowels.* The long vowels of Old Polish had become narrowed vowels (*samogłoski pochylone*) by about 1500: a narrowed *a* between *a* and *o*; a narrowed *e* between *e* and *i* or *y*; a narrowed *o* between *o* and *u*, which became the modern *ó*. Which words had them is a fact about each word, and the prints are no reliable guide. Printers usually marked the narrowed *é* and *ó* with an accent, but for *a* they usually did the opposite, accenting the clear vowel and leaving the narrowed one plain (Statorius, 1568: *bábá, spác* against *pan, sad*). Practice was inconsistent. A choir that wants narrowed vowels needs a list for the text in hand; the editions do not mark them.

*Reading the old prints.* The diplomatic texts in the critical editions keep the printers' spelling. These are the differences that matter:

| SPELLING                         | SOUND                                    | EXAMPLE                                         |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| <i>y before a vowel, final y</i> | <i>j</i>                                 | <i>Yefu = Jesu, pokoy = pokój</i>               |
| <i>y, i after p, b, m, w</i>     | softness, as modern <i>i</i>             | <i>zmyerzka = zmierzka, swyętego = świętego</i> |
| <i>v at the start of a word</i>  | <i>u</i>                                 | <i>Vżywáyq = używają</i>                        |
| <i>f</i>                         | <i>s</i>                                 | <i>fwey = swej</i>                              |
| <i>ff</i>                        | <i>sz</i>                                | <i>náffym = naszym</i>                          |
| <i>á</i>                         | usually the clear <i>a</i>               | <i>Bogá = Boga</i>                              |
| <i>ē, ā</i>                      | a vowel followed by <i>m</i> or <i>n</i> | <i>zduchē = z Duchem</i>                        |
| <i>words run together</i>        | a preposition joined to its noun         | <i>wćyemności = w ciemności</i>                 |

## OLD POLISH

*Bogurodzica* is sung in Woronczak's normalised text in modern pronunciation. That is the usual practice, and the edition's underlay is built on it. The Polish of about 1400 differed a good deal. Stress fell on the first syllable and moved to the next-to-last only around 1500. Vowels were long or short. There was a single nasal vowel, written *ϙ* in the diplomatic text, which later split into *q* and *ę*. *Ł* was a dark *l* and *rz* the Czech-like *ř*. A sung reconstruction could be built from the historical grammars, but no performing tradition has tested one, and the editions do not print one.

*Kyrie eleison* is Greek: *y* is *i*, and the refrain has seven syllables, KY-ri-e e-LE-i-son.

## LATIN AS SUNG IN POLAND

*Default.* The Polish tradition. Polish choirs sang Latin with Polish sounds for some letters, and Polish churches and schools kept many of them. It differs from the Roman pronunciation that most choirs know in about a dozen spellings. Everything not listed is as in Roman Latin.

| SPELLING                        | POLISH LATIN                       | ROMAN                         | EXAMPLE                  |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------|
| <i>c before e, i, y, ae, oe</i> | <i>ts</i>                          | <i>ch</i> as in <i>church</i> | <i>caelum, principio</i> |
| <i>sc before e, i</i>           | <i>sts</i>                         | <i>sh</i>                     | <i>scio, descendit</i>   |
| <i>ch</i>                       | <i>ch</i> as in <i>loch</i>        | <i>k</i>                      | <i>Rachel</i>            |
| <i>h</i>                        | <i>ch</i> as in <i>loch</i>        | silent                        | <i>Herodis, hodie</i>    |
| <i>g</i>                        | always hard                        | soft before <i>e, i</i>       | <i>angelum</i>           |
| <i>gn</i>                       | <i>g</i> and <i>n</i> both sounded | <i>ny</i>                     | <i>agnus</i>             |
| <i>qu</i>                       | <i>kv</i>                          | <i>kw</i>                     | <i>qui</i>               |
| <i>ngu before a vowel</i>       | <i>ngv</i>                         | <i>ngw</i>                    | <i>sanguis</i>           |
| <i>s between vowels</i>         | <i>z</i>                           | <i>s</i> or <i>z</i>          | <i>misit, Iesu</i>       |
| <i>ti before a vowel</i>        | <i>tsi</i>                         | <i>tsi</i>                    | <i>gratia</i>            |
| <i>z</i>                        | <i>z</i>                           | <i>dz</i>                     | <i>zelus</i>             |
| <i>ae, oe</i>                   | <i>e</i> as in <i>bed</i>          | the same                      | <i>saecula</i>           |
| <i>y</i>                        | <i>i</i>                           | the same                      | <i>Kyrie</i>             |

*Vowels and syllables.* Five pure vowels, none reduced. Unlike Polish, *i* before a vowel is a syllable of its own: GRA-ti-a, Ma-RI-a, FI-li-os. The sixteenth-century Polish forms of these words show it: *gracyja, Maryja*.

*Ci, si, ti, di, ri before a vowel.* These stay hard, as in Italian, and are not softened as Polish would soften them. The Polish loans of the period have hard consonants (*lekcyja, pasyja, historyja*). *N* before *i* is another matter. Polish speakers soften it, and the loans have a soft *n* (*unija, Antoni*), so it may stay soft.

*Ti.* *tsi* with a full *i*: ex-spe-cta-ti-O-ne. Not after *s, t, x*: HO-sti-a. Polish schools now often teach a plain *ti*; the church tradition and the period have *tsi*.

*S between vowels.* *z*: MI-zit, JE-zu. The Polish loans voice it (*muzyka, filozof, Jezus*), and the series follows them.

*G before e and i.* Hard. Medieval Polish readers said *j* here, which is why *angelus* became *anioł* and *evangelium* *ewangelija*; the hard *g* is the later learned norm. When it took over in sung Latin is not known. For fifteenth-century repertory, *j* is a historical option.

*Qu.* *kv*, which Polish voicing rules turn into *kf* in quick speech. Either is right.

*Stress.* By the rules of Latin, not of Polish: the next-to-last syllable if it is long, otherwise the one before. Jerzy Liban's treatise on church accentuation (Kraków, c. 1539) teaches these rules, and Polish kept Latin stress even in borrowed words (MU-zy-ka). Do not move the stress to the next-to-last syllable: DO-mi-nus, AN-ge-lum, e-RI-pu-it, FI-li-os, NO-lu-it.

#### FURTHER READING

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